century.) Using membership of the United Nations as a criterion, there were just fifty-one recognized sovereign states in 1945, 117 by 1965, and 154 by 1980. In other words, over 100 new sovereign states arose in just thirty-five years.

Both the United States and the Soviet Union made efforts to attract and influence these newly independent states, including through foreign aid, military support, and technical assistance. For the United States, the focus of reconstruction efforts was initially on Europe and Japan. For the Soviet Union, actual communism initially flourished only in Central and Eastern Europe and parts of East Asia. Other areas remained contested, and the Cold War played out brutally across the world, from Cuba and Chile to Angola and Yemen. For the Soviet Union, preserving or advancing the 'people's revolution' required heavy-handed military interventions, including in Hungary, Czechoslovakia, and later Afghanistan. For the United States and the West, upholding a liberal international order involved supporting some very brutal and illiberal regimes if it meant countering the challenge of the Soviet Union. This applied to Guatemala, Iran, South Africa, Pakistan, Indonesia, and the Philippines; Washington was even hesitant about some efforts to stop genocide and ethnic cleansing, as in Bangladesh or Cambodia. Those who romantically recall the Cold War as a simpler time—or, worse, a period of international peace (which applied, if at all, only to Europe)—ignore this tragic and messy global story. [4]

Debating the Foundations: After Independence in 1947

Although a freedom movement had been gaining steam for some time in India, it was in the context of the early Cold War that Independence occurred suddenly on 15 August 1947. As one British historian would write decades later, 'The British Empire did not decline, it simply fell.' [5] The rashness with which the Indian Subcontinent's future was decided was, in hindsight, shocking. A provisional government for India was announced in August 1946, the status of the semi-autonomous princely states was only seriously addressed after January 1947, and an Independence plan was